work. Questions are being raised about the availability of work for all the labour in the world.

We should look at the emerging situation carefully. If necessary, humanity should get ready to accept that the full employment of the labour force would not be needed to produce all the goods and services required for human consumption. It might become necessary for governments to frame policies to deal with excess labour.

Understanding Employment

In 1947, all member countries of the ILO agreed (some upgradation was made in 1982) on certain basic definitions and understandings of labour. A broad construct of employment and unemployment was created. All people above the age of fifteen are now (earlier people in the age group of fifteen to sixty-four) considered part of the ‘working age’ population. This working age population is divided into two broad sub-groups of being ‘in the labour force’ and ‘not in labour force’. The working age population recorded as being in the labour force is considered the ‘economically active population’. Those in the labour force or the economically active population who get jobs are considered employed and those who do not get jobs are considered unemployed or ‘not employed’. The labour force thus comprises two sets of workers: ‘employed’ and ‘not employed or unemployed’.

These definitions enable understanding of key relationships of labour, employment and jobs in the economy. The definitions of total population, working age population, population in labour force, population employed and population unemployed depict the state of labour, employment and unemployment in the economy. The ratio of population of age fifteen and above to the total population gives the working age population ratio.

Let us take India’s population as on 31 December 2020 to be 138 crore and the population aged fifteen and above at 103 crore. In such a case, the working age would be 103 crore and the ratio of working age population to